



# The only good orc is a dead orc: does playing good or evil monster races influence ethnocentrism in real life? A brief report

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## ABSTRACT

Does killing orcs in fantasy games make people feel racist toward other people in real life? Recent controversies within role-playing games have focused on whether playing with inherently evil monster races increases ethnocentrism in real life. This has led some game makers to change the content of their games away from themes of good humans, elves, and dwarves fighting evil monster races, to themes of moral ambiguity where any race can be good or evil. This has also resulted in pushbacks from some players who claim these efforts cater to politically left narratives on race and identity that are themselves harmful. For the current study, the belief that fighting against evil orcs contributes to racist attitudes was tested with a sample of 102 young adults. Participants were randomized to play a video game with either inherently evil orcs, or those that were morally neutral. Participants were then tested with regard to ethnocentrism. No evidence emerged that playing in a game with evil orcs increased ethnocentrism. This evidence finds that causal concerns about role-playing games with evil monsters may be misplaced.

Historically, role-playing games such as *Dungeons and Dragons* and related video games were open ended fantasy games, often focused on good-versus-evil narratives. In such games, evil was often represented by particular monster races, such as orcs, the famous bad guys from the *Lord of the Rings* books and movie series. However, in the past few years, concerns emerged that portraying monsters as inherently evil may be synonymous with racial stereotyping in real life and may promote racism and ethnocentrism. Although such debates are often passionate, they were seldom evidence based and little data was available to either support or refute such beliefs. The current study seeks to contribute to the small but emerging pool of data by considering the impact of playing as evil or neutral orcs in video games and examining whether this contributes to ethnocentric attitudes (a preference for one's own ethnic group and suspiciousness or dislike toward others).

### Brief literature review

As noted, concerns about evil monster portrayals have emerged as a significant issue for video games and role-playing games in recent years. Much of the debate has taken place in online journalistic spaces (e.g., [1]), which may not always be conducive to a reasoned and objective consideration of the evidence. The expressed concern is that monster

racism, such as orcs, take on qualities of real-life racial groups such as Africans or Asians, promoting racial stereotypes and potentially leading to racism in real life. Scholars have expressed this concern about race depictions of zombies such as in the controversial *Resident Evil 5* game which took place in Africa [2]. It is not clear how often this is true. One study of the *Dungeons and Dragons* game, found little evidence for racial stereotypes in the depiction of orc monsters [3], although some studies of video games have raised this concern of racial stereotyping in fictional races in some video games [4]. In some cases, concerns about depictions of monster races has led to changes to some game systems such as *Dungeons and Dragons* incorporating progressive views and even jargon on race; yet unpopular with a wider range of players less interested in moral lessons in their games (see discussions by [5;6]). There is some data to suggest this may have had a negative financial impact on these game systems (e.g., [7]), however less is known about whether the practical implications of monster races are verified.

Because so few studies have been done on this issue previously, it is difficult to summarize prior literature. However, this provides significant opening for new research. Thus far, only a single study has examined this issue within the context of *Dungeons and Dragons* [8]. Surveying

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a wide range of adults, both players and non-players, results indicated that playing Dungeons and Dragons was not associated with ethnocentric attitudes. Further, most individuals did not find depictions of orcs as inherently evil to be either offensive or racist. This included non-whites, who were no more likely than whites to find such depictions to be problematic.

Experimental studies of Dungeons and Dragons are difficult, as the game can take hours to set up and tends to unfold over weeks or months. However, similar debates have struck video games as well as pencil-and-paper role-playing games. Many video games are based on Dungeons or Dragons or other fantasy adventure outlets such as *Lord of the Rings*. Generally, the evidence that playing video games influences negative outcomes such as aggression has been slim (e.g., [9;10;11;12]). Studies of race or racism in video games are fewer. In one study [13], players tended to rate black avatars more positively than white avatars after competitive or cooperative tasks. Another study[14] found little evidence for an effect of avatar race on use of stereotypes, aggressive cognition, behavior or affect. However, examining monster races in the video game context has not been done and the briefer time required for video gaming as opposed to pencil-and-paper gaming makes this medium more conducive to experimental study.

At present, there are few studies examining the impact of playing monster races in video games and whether these may impact racist attitudes in real life. Previous studies generally have found little evidence that playing video games has a substantial impact on real life attitudes and behaviors. An experimental study of fictional races in video games could help illustrate whether the concerns of some advocates have merit. As such, this study seeks to examine the potentially causal impact of playing as evil or non-evil orcs on ethnocentric attitudes in an experimental context. Our hypotheses are:

**H1:** Playing a game in which players fight against inherently evil orcs as opposed to playing with morally neutral orcs will increase ethnocentric attitudes.

**H2:** Players who played the game with evil orcs will rate the game as more offensive than those who played with morally neutral orcs.

1. Methods

A preregistration of the study is available at: <https://osf.io/mt4yq>.  
**Participants**

Our initial participant pool was 121, but 19 (15.7 %) were eliminated after successfully guessing the hypothesis on debriefing. As such, final participants in the study were 102 undergraduate students at a liberal arts university in the US south. The mean age of participants was 20.5 ( $SD = 3.83$ ). 52 % of the sample were female, with 2 individuals not reporting biological sex. Regarding ethnicity, 39.2 % were white, 19.6 % were black, 24.5 % were Latino, 4.9 % were Asian, and 11.8 % were other. Participants were recruited via a computerized recruitment system for the psychology department. Participants consisted mainly of first-year and second-year students. Demographic characteristics are presented in Table 1.

Materials

Table 1  
Demographic Characteristics of the Sample.

|                  |                      |
|------------------|----------------------|
| Mean age:        | 20.5 ( $SD = 3.83$ ) |
| Sex:             |                      |
| Male:            | 46 %                 |
| Female:          | 52 %                 |
| Unreported:      | 2 %                  |
| Ethnicity:       |                      |
| White:           | 39.2 %               |
| Black:           | 19.6 %               |
| Latino/Hispanic: | 24.5 %               |
| Asian:           | 4.9 %                |
| Other:           | 11.8 %               |

**Video Games.** For this experiment, two games were selected for their similarity in genre (fantasy adventure) but differing in the presentation of orcs. *Shadows of Mordor* (SOM) is a video game based on the Lord of the Rings series in which players fight as heroes, mainly against evil orcs. This also was selected given that the *Lord of the Rings* series has sometimes been criticized (rightly or wrongly, see [3] for content that was racially stereotyping in terms of the orc monsters. By contrast, *Skyrim* is an open-ended fantasy adventure in which players can play as a variety of races. Commentators have noted that *Skyrim* was written such that race is treated more neutrally than in other games (e.g., [15]). In this experiment, participants were set to play as an orc character. The game mainly follows a good versus evil storyline, though characters have some flexibility in choices they make. As such, it's best to consider orcs in this game as morally ambiguous as opposed to inherently evil in the *Shadows of Mordor* (SOM) game. Both games were out within a few years of each other (2011–2014), are of a similar genre, have similar game play and are largely based on the Lord of the Rings/Dungeons and Dragons lore. As such, the video games were chosen to be as similar as possible [9]aside from the evil/neutral nature of the orcs in the game.

**Video Game Ratings.** Participants were asked to rate the video games related to how exciting (4 items,  $\alpha = 0.923$ ), competitive (5 items,  $\alpha = 0.735$ ) and difficult (3 items,  $\alpha = 0.890$ ) they were. Independent *t*-tests revealed that the games did not differ in terms of how exciting they were, but did differ in regards to difficulty with SOM rated as more difficult ( $M = 2.39$ ,  $SD = 0.90$ ) than *Skyrim* ( $M = 1.76$ ,  $SD = 0.81$ ),  $t(100) = 3.69$ ,  $p < 0.001$ ). SOM was also rated as more competitive ( $M = 2.88$ ,  $SD = 0.65$ ) than *Skyrim* ( $M = 2.43$ ,  $SD = 0.74$ ),  $t(100) = 3.28$ ,  $p = 0.001$ ). As such, difficulty and competitiveness will be included as covariates in subsequent analyses. Players were also asked a single question about the degree to which they found the game to be offensive.

**Distractor Tasks.** The hypotheses of video game studies can be easy to detect and demand characteristics can influence study results. In our study, we included two surveys, namely of music preferences and mating preferences, to make our hypotheses less obvious. Participants filled these out along with the ethnocentrism outcome measure. As there were no actual hypotheses regarding these measures, we don't discuss them further.

**Ethnocentrism.** Ethnocentrism is feature of racism that involves explicit preferences for one's own ethnic group and corresponding non-preference for interacting with those from other ethnic groups, or negative attitudes toward other ethnicities. The Multiethnic Climate Inventory, a 10-item Likert scale [16]was used to measure ethnocentrism with the current study. "I don't like some other races or cultures" and "I want to do social things only with people of my own race and culture" are two examples of questions from this survey. For the current study, coefficient alpha was 0.835.

**Procedure.** All procedures described within passed local IRB. Informed consent was obtained from all participants. This included a renewal of informed consent upon debriefing. Upon entry to the lab, participants filled out an informed consent, then were randomized to one of the video game conditions. Participants played the game for 30 min. After playing the game, participants filled out all surveys including the distractor questionnaires, ethnocentrism, and video game ratings. Following this, participants were debriefed and specifically asked to guess the study hypothesis.

2. Results

Main Analyses

As preregistered, all analyses were 2 (game) x 2 (biological sex) ANCOVA analyses, with difficulty and competitiveness used as covariates.

For the outcome related to ethnocentrism, video game condition was non-significant  $F(1, 94) = 2.24$ ,  $p = 0.138$ . No other predictor was related to this outcome. Similarly, for ratings of offensiveness of the

game, game condition had no impact  $F(1, 94) = 1.64, p = 0.203$ . Only the difficulty rating predicted this outcome ( $p = 0.002$ ).

### 3. Discussion

The issue of whether depicting monster races as inherently evil could be problematic in the real world has been a topic of debate for several years. Our study sought to examine related concerns in an experimental manipulation of role-playing video game content. Our results suggest that exposure to evil orc monster races is not a concern as relates to ethnocentrism in real life. Nor was there any evidence people found games with evil orcs to be more offensive. As such, this paper makes the following substantial contributions to our knowledge:

- Portrayal of evil orcs in role playing video games had no impact on real-life racist attitudes.
- Portrayal of evil orcs was not perceived as offensive by players.

The latter finding, related to offensiveness, is particularly interesting in light of the fact that our participants were highly weighed towards non-whites. Much of the debate about evil monsters has focused on the notion that non-whites might be made anxious, traumatized, or “triggered” by such depictions. However, despite having a majority of non-white participants including significant proportions of both black and Latino participants, this concern did not materialize. One possibility is that a relatively small number of online activists are purporting to speak for nonwhite individuals who, as a community, largely do not actually care about this issue or find these depictions to be offensive.

The finding that playing games with evil monsters is good news as we can be more comfortable with people playing such games without worrying over the consequences. To the extent that games producers, either pencil-and-paper or video games, have altered games to cater to a moral movement of a few, this simply may not be necessary and may even be counterproductive if this increases neuroticism around issues of identity, or simply results in reduced profits due to alienating regular non-activist customers. Game companies should, instead, focus on issues known to affect player satisfaction such as visual quality (e.g., [17]), quality of network data transmission (e.g., [18]), storyline, etc.

Overall, the current results fit with those from prior studies which suggest that video game content has little impact on player attitudes and behaviors. Although issues related to racism and other identity-based injustices are worthwhile to consider, it may be that fictional media has too limited impact on such outcomes to be a primary focus of concern.

#### Practical considerations

Replications of the current study are encouraged. It is important in this work, particularly given how salient race issues have been in recent years, that hypotheses of studies are masked with distractor tasks and surveys to prevent the potential for false positive outcomes. Similarly, game conditions should be carefully matched, and smallest effect size of interest (SESOI) set at a minimum of  $r = 0.10$  to prevent false positive “noise” results which can mislead.

Regarding practical implications for game designers, there does not as of yet appear to be evidence that avoiding evil monster races in game narratives provides for any particularly societal benefit. Although both good vs evil and more nuanced narratives can be interesting, there appears to be no harm in assigning orcs or other monsters as inherently evil. Players appear sophisticated enough to not apply this to real-life racism.

#### Limitations and future studies

As with all studies, this one has limitations. The use of a college sample, naturally this reduces generalizability outside of such samples. Furthermore, it is possible that the video games may have differed from each other in ways that are unmeasured and unexpected.

The current study only employed two video games. It is possible that different results could be achieved with alternative games. As such,

replication studies which examine other games would be welcome. The current games were role playing games and perhaps games from other genres may see different outcomes.

Future studies may wish to consider content in video games as relates to evil monster races and other race-based content from a longitudinal perspective, which may be better suited to examining selection effects as apply to media. It would be interesting to see, as well, more studies with table-top roleplaying games such as Dungeons and Dragons although, given the time commitment such games entail, this may require greater investment on the part of researchers.

### 4. Conclusions

In recent years some scholars and game players have expressed concerns that games with monster races could promote racial stereotypes. Despite concerns that inherently evil orcs in games might be related to racism in real life, the present study could find no evidence to support such a belief. Furthermore, there was no evidence most people found such depictions to be offensive. This latter finding about offensiveness is particularly interesting for a sample in which nonwhite individuals were overrepresented. It may be that individuals who express the most outrage regarding race depictions of orcs, may not be speaking for the larger gaming community, including non-white players. It appears that concerns about evil orcs are similar to other moral panics related to media and technology.

#### Declarations

#### Funding

There was no funding for this study.

**Ethical Approval:** IRB approval was obtained by the Stetson University IRB. All research was performed in accordance with relevant guidelines/regulations applicable when human participants are involved (e.g. Declaration of Helsinki, or similar).

**Informed Consent:** Informed consent was obtained from all participants.

**Authors' contributions:** CJF designed the study, analyzed results, and wrote the first draft. All other authors (CB, DL, BK, AK, JK, SM, JQ, CR, NS, CW) contributed equally to collecting data, entering data into SPSS and editing the final draft and are presented in alphabetical order.

#### Author's Note

Aside from the first author, all subsequent author names are in alphabetical order.

**Preregistration:** <https://osf.io/mt4yq>.

#### CRediT authorship contribution statement

**Christopher J. Ferguson:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Cassandra Bradley:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Breanna Karon:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Ashleigh Korn:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Jenna Kotschessa:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Deandra Lazos:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Shardae Madison:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Jessie Quince:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Cassie Rice:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Noureen Saeed:** Writing – original draft, Data curation. **Chloe Washington:** Writing – original draft, Data curation.

#### Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

#### Data availability

Data are openly available as described in the manuscript

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